

KEYBOARD

60% Keyboard

A 60% keyboard removes the function row, numpad, and navigation cluster, reducing the keyboard to around 60% of a full-sized layout. This ultra-compact form factor is popular among minimalist enthusiasts and gamers who prefer a streamlined setup with maximum desk space for mouse movement. Functionality is retained through layer shortcuts for accessing missing keys.

ABS Keycaps

ABS keycaps are commonly found on standard keyboards due to their affordability and ease of manufacturing. However, ABS keycaps wear down faster than PBT, becoming shiny and smooth with heavy use. While they may be less durable, ABS keycaps are lightweight and provide a standard, smooth typing experience, often found in both budget and mid-range mechanical keyboards.

Actuation Point

The actuation point is the distance a key needs to be pressed before it registers. For example, Cherry MX Red switches have an actuation point of 2mm. Shorter actuation distances, like in speed switches, allow for quicker key presses, making them ideal for fast-paced gaming. In contrast, longer actuation distances can provide more deliberate input for typing or work.

Anti-Ghosting

Ghosting occurs when pressing several keys simultaneously causes additional, unintended keypresses to register. Anti-ghosting technology prevents this by allowing only the intended keys to register. For gamers, especially in action-heavy titles or competitive play, anti-ghosting ensures accurate input, preventing frustrating misinputs during intense gameplay.

Clicky Switches

Clicky switches, such as Cherry MX Blue, are characterized by both tactile feedback and an audible click at the actuation point. These switches are loved by typists for the satisfying “click” sound, though they can be noisy in shared spaces. Clicky switches provide clear feedback with every keystroke, making them ideal for those who prefer a more audible typing experience.

Custom Keyboard Builds

Building custom mechanical keyboards from scratch allows enthusiasts to tailor every aspect of their keyboard, from switch type to case material, layout, and keycap profile. Custom keyboard building is a popular hobby among hardcore enthusiasts, providing full control over aesthetics, typing feel, and functionality.

Hot-Swappable Switches

Hot-swappable keyboards allow users to replace the mechanical switches without desoldering, making it easy to customize

the feel of each key. This feature is ideal for enthusiasts who enjoy experimenting with different switch types (e.g., tactile, linear, clicky) or for those who want to replace worn-out switches without needing specialized tools or technical skills.

Key Rollover (NKRO)

Key rollover refers to the number of keys that can be pressed simultaneously and registered by the keyboard. NKRO (N-key rollover) means every keypress is detected, even when pressing multiple keys at once. This feature is critical for gamers who often press multiple keys simultaneously (e.g., movement, crouching, and jumping), as well as for fast typists.

Stabilizers

Stabilizers are used on larger keys like the spacebar, shift, and enter keys to prevent wobbling and ensure smooth keystrokes. High-end stabilizers, such as GMK or Durock, are often lubed and clipped by enthusiasts to reduce rattle and improve the feel of the keyboard. Poor-quality stabilizers can cause unwanted noise and a mushy feeling during typing.

Keycap Legends

The legends on keycaps are the printed characters on each key. High-quality keycaps use double-shot or dye-sublimation techniques to ensure legends do not fade over time. Double-shot keycaps inject two layers of plastic, ensuring durability, while dye-sublimated legends are printed directly into the keycap. Enthusiasts prefer durable legends for longevity and readability.

Keycap Profile

Keycap profiles refer to the shape and height of the keycaps. Popular profiles include OEM, Cherry, SA, and DSA. Cherry profile is often preferred for its low height and ergonomics, while SA is known for its tall, spherical design, offering a retro aesthetic. The choice of keycap profile affects the typing feel and comfort, with enthusiasts swapping keycaps to match their preferences.

Keycap Puller

A keycap puller is a tool used to remove keycaps from mechanical keyboards. This tool is essential for enthusiasts who frequently swap keycaps or need to clean their keyboard. Wire-style pullers are preferred as they avoid scratching the keycap or switch, and they are commonly used in custom keyboard communities where keycap swapping and customization are routine practices.

Linear Switches

Linear switches, such as Cherry MX Red, provide a smooth keystroke with no tactile bump or audible click. They are preferred by gamers due to their fast, consistent keypresses, which reduce resistance and allow for quicker double-taps and rapid keystrokes. These switches are ideal for FPS and RTS games where responsiveness and precision are crucial. 